

Mingpu Xiao

Department of Political Science, University of California, San Diego

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EDUCATION

University of California, San Diego 09/2021 - 06/2027 (Expected)

Ph.D., Political Science with Specialization in Computational Social Science

Subfields: Comparative Politics, Political Methodology

Dissertation Chairs: Margaret E. Roberts, Victor Shih

Committee: J. Lawrence Broz, Megumi Naoi, Francisco Garfias

University of California, San Diego 09/2018 - 06/2020

Master of International Affairs, School of Global Policy and Strategy

Career Track: International Economics

Nanjing University 09/2015 - 06/2018

M.A. in Political Science, School of Government

Certificate in Chinese and American Studies, Hopkins–Nanjing Center (2017)

Beijing Institute of Technology 09/2011 - 06/2015

B.A. in Economics

RESEARCH

Research Interests: Authoritarian Politics; Political Economy; Information Politics and Public Opinion; Computational Social Science; Causal Inference

Dissertation: *The Political Logic of State-Owned Enterprises: Legitimacy, State Capacity, and Elite Power-Sharing*

Job Market Paper: *Legitimizing State Capitalism: Nationalism and Public Support for State Ownership in China*

Why do citizens support state ownership despite its widely perceived inefficiency? This paper argues that nationalism provides a key source of legitimacy for China's state-capitalist system. Using party newspapers, nationally representative surveys, a factorial difference-in-differences design, and a conjoint experiment, I show that the Chinese state has reframed state-owned enterprises as national symbols and that nationalism increases public support for state ownership, driven primarily by perceptions of SOEs as protection against external threats.

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Articles

- Xiao, Mingpu, and Tangbiao Xiao. 2017. "Determinants of Public Attitudes toward Political Order: Evidence from a Sample Survey in Province C, China" (in Chinese). *Administrative Tribune* 24(5). (CSSCI)

Book Chapters

- Xiao, Mingpu, and Tangbiao Xiao. "The Evolution, Typology, and Characteristics of Chinese Citizens' Economic Values" (in Chinese). In *Report on Social Governance in the New Era*, edited by Wenfang Tang, Jie Chen, and Tangbiao Xiao. Guangzhou: Sun Yat-sen University Press. (Forthcoming 2026)

WORKING PAPERS

- “Legitimizing State Capitalism: Nationalism and Public Support for State Ownership.” (Job Market Paper; prepared for submission)
- “International Origins of Populism: WTO and U.S. Presidential Elections” (with Marc-Andreas Muendler, T. Renee Bowen, and J. Lawrence Broz; co-first author with Marc-Andreas Muendler).
- “Public Perceptions of Political Order: Concept, Measurement, and Typology” (with Tangbiao Xiao; in Chinese).

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

“Socialism with Chinese Characteristics 2.0: How Nationalism Drives Public Support for State-Owned Economy”

- Chinese Politics Mini-Conference, American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting, Boston, September 2026. (Accepted)
- Young Scholars Conference, Fudan–UC Center on Contemporary China, San Diego, May 2026.
- Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Annual Conference, Chicago, April 2026.

GRANTS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND AWARDS

2026	Yankelovich Center Research Grant, UC San Diego (\$3,500)
2024–2025	Dean’s Research and Travel Grant, UC San Diego (\$1,000)
2020	Richard Covington Best Paper Award, School of Global Policy and Strategy, UC San Diego
2019	Dean’s Fellowship, School of Global Policy and Strategy, UC San Diego
2016–2018	First-Class Graduate Fellowship, Nanjing University
2017	National Scholarship, Ministry of Education of China
2017	Huang Chengfeng Research Fellow, Hopkins–Nanjing Center
2017	Student Delegate, Chicago Forum on Global Cities

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant 2022 – Present

21st Century China Center, UC San Diego

- *China from the Ground Up Survey*: designed, coordinated, and fielded online surveys of Chinese citizens’ political attitudes; analyzed and visualized survey data and disseminated findings to academic and public audiences.
- Collected and analyzed data on local government debt in China.
- Maintained a large-scale corpus of Chinese newspapers.

Research Associate 2020 – 2021

Center for Commerce and Diplomacy, UC San Diego

- Applied causal inference and machine learning methods to analyze the impact of WTO Appellate Body rulings on U.S. presidential elections, resulting in the working paper “International Origins of Populism: WTO and U.S. Presidential Elections.”

Robinson Summer Research Fellow

Summer 2019

School of Global Policy and Strategy, UC San Diego

- Analyzed data from eight survey experiments testing the causal effects of international election observation and foreign meddling on trust in elections; findings were incorporated into the book *Monitors and Meddlers: How Foreign Actors Influence Local Trust in Elections* (by Sarah S. Bush and Lauren Prather).

Research Assistant

2015 – 2018

Center for Public Affairs and Local Governance, Nanjing University

- *Chinese Citizens' Political Values Survey* (2015–2018): contributed to questionnaire design and data collection; applied model-based statistical inference to measure and predict citizens' political values along dimensions such as democracy, order, the rule of law, and civil liberties (Jiangsu Province).
- *Asian Barometer Survey* (2015): conducted fieldwork in urban and rural Anhui Province as a survey team supervisor; organized GIS-based household sampling and completed questionnaire data collection.
- *Local Governance and Reform* (2016–2018): contributed to survey design and data collection and interviewed local government officials; combined quantitative analysis with case studies to examine the relationships among urbanization, local administrative reform, public attitudes, and political participation (Pukou District, Nanjing).
- *Grassroots Elections and Democracy in Rural China* (2012, 2015): conducted fieldwork in rural Jiangxi Province, observing village committee elections, interviewing village cadres and villagers, and collecting survey data; wrote research reports analyzing the relationships among lineage networks, social capital, electoral participation, and public goods provision.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Political Inquiry

Fall 2025, Spring 2025

Teaching Assistant and Discussion Section Instructor, UC San Diego

- Independently designed and taught weekly lecture-style discussion sections on core course content with original teaching materials.

Introduction to Comparative Politics

Winter 2025, Fall 2024, Fall 2023

Teaching Assistant and Discussion Section Instructor, UC San Diego

- Independently designed and taught weekly lecture-style discussion sections on core course content with original teaching materials.

Analysis for Political Science

Summer 2023

Teaching Assistant, UC San Diego

Policy Responses to Global Issues (Graduate)

Fall 2023

Teaching Assistant, UC San Diego

SKILLS

- **Research methods:** computational text analysis; causal inference with observational data; randomized experimental design (field and survey experiments); measurement models; machine learning and large language models (fine-tuning BERT-family models, LoRA fine-tuning of open-source LLMs, API-based workflows)
- **Programming and data:** R, Python, Stata, SQL (MySQL), L^AT_EX, ArcGIS;
- **Languages:** Chinese (native); English (fluent)

REFERENCES

Margaret E. Roberts (Advisor)
Professor, Department of Political Science
University of California, San Diego
meroberts@ucsd.edu

Victor Shih (Advisor)
Professor, School of Global Policy and Strategy
University of California, San Diego
vcshih@ucsd.edu

J. Lawrence Broz (Committee Member)
Professor, Department of Political Science
University of California, San Diego
jlbroz@ucsd.edu